In the diary of Wilson there is an entry on 19 May 1920 that notes with some bitterness that 'at 6:30pm came a wire from Teheran [sic] to say our garrison at Enzeli on the Caspian had been surrounded by Bolsheviks & made prisoners! A nice state of affairs which will have a bad effect in the East.'[35] *The improbable had occurred. The retreat of British troops in the face of the Red Army was a humiliation that struck at the very heart of Britain's prestige in South Asia. Officially, the Soviet government denied sanctioning the attack on Enzeli, claiming that it was only informed after the operation was complete*[36] *– a claim the British government and press found dubious, and rightly so.*[37] *Trotsky had apparently planned the event the previous month, cabling Lenin and Chicherin to tell them of the operation.*[38] *On 23 May the Soviet government sent a congratulatory message to the sailors of the Caspian Fleet, thanking them for the 'fatal blow' that had now been dealt to the 'international counter-revolution'.*[39] *Aside from causing the British government a major embarrassment, the immediate effect of the landings was to open up communication between the Bolsheviks and the various revolutionary agitators in Persia and, in particular, to provide support to the Janglis. Indeed, collaboration between the Bolshevik regime and the Janglis would see the takeover of the provincial capital of Gilan, Recht, and the ultimate creation of the Soviet Republic of Iran.*[40]

This Republic, however, was to prove short lived. For although they may have been busy sending the Red Army into Persia, the Bolshevik government had still not resolved the contradictions in their policy towards Asian nationalists, pan-Islamists and Communists. Confusion over who they should be supporting hampered the Bolsheviks in these early years when it came to extending their influence in Persia. Hence, while there were those in Moscow who warned against trying to impose communist practice on the Persian people too soon, others disagreed. Unruly local Ghilan Communists ignored Lenin and his comrades and set about encouraging class terror, creating peasant Soviets and unveiling Muslim women.[41] Such radicalism, however, alienated Kuchik Khan and his Janglis and spelt the downfall of the Soviet Republic in Iran.[42]

Meanwhile, back in London, Churchill was furious. Despite its earlier vacillations, by early May the general staff had actually warned that the